and shouted: "*Sovyetki! Raus!*"

Panic appeared in the women's eyes. One stumbled, clutching her apron, and both turned and ran out of the canteen.

"What happened?" Rose asked.

"They're from the Soviet Union," Léa said. Rose looked confused. "The Italian woman next to me speaks some French. She said Soviet citizens rank the lowest," Léa explained.

"Where do they eat if they can't come in here?"

"Maybe they have their own canteens?"

"They can't work ten-hour shifts without eating." Rose stabbed her fork into the cake. It didn't seem fair to eat it now.

"It goes to show, even when we think things are terrible for us, there's always someone worse off," Léa said.

Rose glanced at the two Frenchmen talking at the table next to them. "Do you think they're former prisoners of war?"

"Maybe. I met an Italian former prisoner of war this morning. He works at one of the watchmaking factories in town."

"Look, they're leaving." She sat up straight, watching as the men rose from their table. "I want to ask if they know André."

"Rose, don't get your hopes up. The chance of you finding—"

"*Bonjour, monsieur*," Rose said.

The men stopped, surprised to see Frenchwomen. "*Bonjour, mesdemoiselles*."

"How long have you been in Germany?" Rose asked.

"We were captured by the Wehrmacht in nineteen-forty, and held as POWs before being given the chance to change our status to workers. We have family to support in France, so we send our salaries back home. What are you doing here? Is it true that Laval insists on sending women to Germany, too?"

Rose barely registered Léa kicking her under the table. Hope fluttered in her chest—maybe these men would help her find André. She gripped the coffee cup with both hands.

"My sister and I volunteered." She watched their faces darken. "Do you know André—"

One of men leaned over and spat in Rose's coffee. "We don't talk to traitors." He turned to his friend. "Come on, let's go."